```
{
  "_index" : "movies",
  "_type" : "_doc",
  "_id" : "999",
  "found" : false
}
```

We can of course find out if the document exists in the store beforehand by using the read API but with the HTTP `HEAD` action on the resource URL. For example, the following query checks if the movie with ID `1` exists.

**Listing 5.8 Checking if a document exists**

```
HEAD movies/_doc/1
```

This query returns `200–OK` if the document exists. If the document is unavailable in the store, a `404 Not Found` error is returned to the client, as figure 5.7 shows.

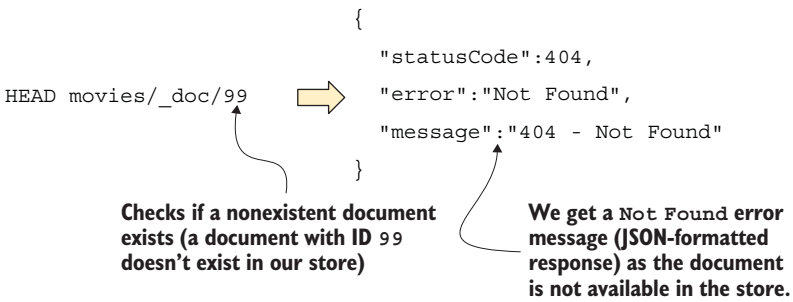



**Figure 5.7 Fetching a nonexistent document returns a "Not Found" message.**

We can send a `HEAD` request to the server to determine if the document exists before requesting it. If you think this incurs an additional round trip to the server, indeed it does. Based on the `HEAD` request's response, we may (or may not) have to send another request to fetch the actual object. Instead, we can use a `GET` request to start with, which returns the document if it exists or a `Not Found` message if not. Of course, the choice is yours.

So far, we've fetched only a single document for a single index. How can we satisfy the requirement of fetching multiple documents with IDs from either the same index or multiple indexes? For example, how can we fetch two documents with IDs 1 and 2 from the `movies` index? We can use a multi-document API called `_mget`, which is the topic of the next section.

### 5.2.2 Retrieving multiple documents

In the previous section, we used a single-document API to fetch one document at a time. However, we may have requirements like these: